

FACTFILE
REAL NAME
T'Challa
OCCUPATION
Monarch of Wakanda
BASE
Wakanda
HEIGHT 6 ft
WEIGHT 200 lbs
EYES Brown
HAIR Black

FIRST APPEARANCE
Fantastic Four #52
(July 1966)

Olympic-level athlete, acrobat and gymnast; combat specialist. Mask enhances night vision; gloves expel gases; vibranium boots enable him to land from great heights; vibranium in costume makes bullets or punches lose power.

BLACK PANTHER

The "Black Panther" is an honorary title bestowed on the reigning monarch of the jungle kingdom of Wakanda. T'Challa was only a child when he succeeded his father, who had been murdered by Klaw, the master of sound. Before T'Challa assumed his throne, he was educated in the finest schools in Europe and America and then embarked on a series of grueling tests to prove that he was worthy of donning the mantle and using the powers of the Black Panther. Although T'Challa often allied himself with the FANTASTIC FOUR and the AVENGERS, the people of Wakanda are always his highest priority. Realizing that the time had come for him to father an heir, he married Ororo Munroe, STORM of the X-MEN. They sided with CAPTAIN AMERICA's resistance during the Civil War (see pp. 84-5), and they fought off a SKRULL invasion of Wakanda during the Secret Invasion (see pp. 326-7). Recently, DR. DOOM critically wounded T'Challa, and his sister Shuri stepped in to fill his role as the Black Panther. **TD, MF**

Ally from Africa: claws at the ready, the resourceful Black Panther springs into action alongside the Fantastic Four, whom he has aided on several occasions.



BLACK MAMBA

BLACK TALON

BLACK TOM

FIRST APPEARANCE Marvel Two-In-One #64 (June 1980)
REAL NAME Tanya Sealy
OCCUPATION Mercenary **BASE** Mobile
HEIGHT 5 ft 7 in **WEIGHT** 115 lbs **EYES** Green **HAIR** Black
SPECIAL POWERS/ABILITIES Projects Darkforce energy, which suffocates opponents; hypnotic powers trick targets into thinking that Darkforce is a loved one, allowing it to ensnare them.

FIRST APPEARANCE Avengers #152 (October 1976)
REAL NAME Unrevealed
OCCUPATION Houngan (voodoo priest) **BASE** Louisiana
HEIGHT 6 ft 2 in **WEIGHT** 240 lbs **EYES** Brown **HAIR** Black
SPECIAL POWERS/ABILITIES Supernatural voodoo powers, including the ability to create and control zombies, human corpses that can be reanimated through voodoo magic.

FIRST APPEARANCE X-Men Vol. 1 #99 (June 1976)
REAL NAME Thomas Samuel Eamon Cassidy
OCCUPATION Criminal **BASE** Mobile
HEIGHT 6 ft **WEIGHT** 200 lbs **EYES** Blue **HAIR** Black
SPECIAL POWERS/ABILITIES Can project blasts of heat and concussive force, which he focuses through his shilleagh.

Roxxon Oil surgically altered Tanya Sealy, a former call girl, to become a covert agent. A surgical implant allowed her to tap her brain's energy to control the Darkforce, an inky cloud of energy, and also some hypnotic powers. She formed part of the original incarnations of the SERPENT SQUAD and SERPENT SOCIETY. Later, she also worked with the MASTERS OF EVIL, the B.A.D. Girls, and the Femizons. During the Civil War (see pp.84-5), she sided with CAPTAIN AMERICA's anti-registration forces, but by the time the SECRET INVASION took place, she had rejoined the new Serpent Society. **MT, MF**

Black Talon is a Creole with true voodoo powers. This man, whose real name is unknown, is actually the second to wear the Black Talon costume. The first was a fake voodoo priest who was killed by his own cult when they found out he was a fraud. The true houngan Black Talon formed his own cult and was then contacted by the GRIM REAPER, who wanted his dead brother WONDER MAN brought back to life as a zombie. When Black Talon did this, the Reaper's brother attacked the AVENGERS, who subdued him and then defeated Black Talon himself. **MT**



Brother of Sean Cassidy, Black Tom is an Irish-born mutant. Losing both the Cassidy fortune and the woman he loved, he turned to crime. Partnered with the JUGGERNAUT, Black Tom battled the X-MEN and other heroes many times. After CABLE shot Tom, doctors grafted a wood-like material onto his wounds, transforming him into a sentient humanoid plant. On M-Day, Tom lost his plant powers and returned to his old self. Juggernaut later convinced him to turn himself in for his crimes. **PS**



BLACK WIDOW

Uncompromising and deadly



Natasha has assumed many roles, including surrogate mother, field agent, and implacable opponent of a rival Black Widow.

Shortly after Russia's World War II victory at Stalingrad, a lady, trapped in a burning building, threw her baby to a stranger below—a soldier named Ivan Petrovich. He raised the baby, named Natasha, who turned out to be a superb student, athlete, and ballerina. She married test pilot Alexei Shostakov, but their happiness was cut short. Faking Shostakov's death and leaving Natasha to grieve, the KGB trained him to become the RED GUARDIAN—a Russian super-soldier. The KGB then manipulated Natasha into becoming a spy codenamed Black Widow.

While they don't always see eye-to-eye, Black Widow remains loyal to her old lover, Daredevil.



Martial artist; Olympic-level gymnast; trained spy; cartridges on wrist house various devices: tear-gas, spring-loaded cable, radio transmitter.

HARD TIME

Two espionage missions against Stark Industries brought her into contact with the adventurer HAWKEYE, and it was ultimately he that inspired Natasha to claim her freedom and join SHIELD. A romance between the pair proved short-lived. Encountering the Red Guardian on a mission, she had only just learned his true identity when he was shot and killed, the double shock causing Natasha to withdraw from her relationship with Hawkeye. In the years that followed, Natasha became romantically involved with DAREDEVIL and founded the Champions team of Super Heroes. She also led the AVENGERS during one of its most testing periods, when several members lost their lives. More recently, Natasha became the implacable opponent of a rival Black Widow, Yelena Belova. Natasha also learned that she was just one of many Black Widows and that her memories of her early life were implanted. Recently, while working for IRON MAN's SHIELD, Natasha helped install BUCKY BARNES as the new CAPTAIN AMERICA, and she still works with him now that SHIELD has been dismantled. **AD, MF**

ESSENTIAL STORYLINES

- **Daredevil #87-90** Black Widow and Daredevil move to San Francisco; Black Widow's history is explained.
- **Pale Little Spider #1-3** The origins of Yelena Belova are explained for the first time.
- **Black Widow Vol. 1 #1-3** The two Black Widows, Natasha Romanova and Yelena Belova, go head-to-head and their bitter enmity begins.

FACTFILE
REAL NAME
Natalia (Natasha) Alianovna Romanova
OCCUPATION
Intelligence agent
BASE
New York City
HEIGHT 5 ft 7 in
WEIGHT 125 lbs
EYES Blue
HAIR Red/auburn

FIRST APPEARANCE
Tales of Suspense Vol. 1 #52
(April 1964)

FACTFILE
REAL NAME
Yelena Belova
OCCUPATION
Intelligence agent
BASE
Russia
HEIGHT 5 ft 7 in
WEIGHT 135 lbs
EYES Blue
HAIR Blonde

FIRST APPEARANCE
Inhumans Vol. 2 #5
(March 1999)

Only experience and gadgets separate Belova from the first Black Widow: Belova achieved even higher marks in training; she is also a martial-arts expert and Olympic-level gymnast.



YELENA BELOVA

Like Natasha, Yelena Belova was trained at the KGB's Red Room. She once worked for HYDRA, who had transferred her mind into a SUPER-ADAPTOID body. Yelena now leads the latest version of the THUNDERBOLTS.

